

THE TERRIBLE

“The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents.”

— H P Lovecraft, *The Call of Cthulhu*

H. P. Lovecraft's *Cthulhu* has a cult following among readers of horror fiction, and any game that aims to recreate the chilling, macabre feel of Lovecraft's books could only fall flat on its face.

Or so we thought.

The atmosphere in *Call of Cthulhu: Dark Corners of the Earth* (DCoTE) is—dare I say it?—perfect. It delivers a potent dose of creepiness and horror that will leave you gasping for breath at the end.

The game starts with police detective Jack Walters (you) investigating a disturbance caused by a cult called the Fellowship of Yith in a dilapidated old house in Massachusetts. Unfortunately, the horrors he experiences in the house that day land him right into the Arkham Asylum, blabbering incoherently.

It is six years later now, and Jack Walters, a shadow of his former self, cannot remember what happened to him during his time in the asylum. As he tries to piece together the last few years of his life, a mysterious phone call finds him in the port of Innsmouth,

investigating the disappearance of a young store manager. His simple investigation turns ugly as he finds himself fighting for his life against dark forces beyond his comprehension.

The game is loosely based on Lovecraft's short story *The Shadow over Innsmouth*, which tells of unnamed horrors that befell the little port. Once you've been introduced to its initial chapters, it's an ordeal to wrench yourself away from the game. Colours are dark and subdued, and the cutscenes are presented in an old-film grainy style, and fit in seamlessly with the game itself.

DCoTE is a mix of adventure and first-person shooter, though the bias is clearly on the adventure side—gather clues, speak to people, and solve puzzles. Thankfully, the puzzles involve some cranial activity rather than just running around picking up stuff to fit it here and there—the phrase “good old detective work” comes to mind. Just when the adventure part starts to get tedious and boring, you're thrown into an adrenaline-draining situation that will instantly



Imaging Shrikrishna Patkar